governments around the world to cooperate in expanding trading links and to invest in their own development, instead of pursuing ruinous military budgets. US policy makers considered China, as the world's most populous nation, crucial for ensuring the success of both global economic liberalization and peaceful cooperation.

A second factor favoring China's emergence in the American mind was the popping of the Japanese economic bubble in 1989. Japan's economic miracle had elevated the country from a ruined and defeated aggressor in 1945 to the world's second-largest economy by 1972. Democratization had taken firm hold in Japan, holding open the prospect of broader liberalization in Asia. During the 1980s, Americans had warily watched Japan's rise to seeming economic dominance, and many assumed it would soon begin flexing its political and even military muscle. Dark warnings about a coming clash between America and Japan soured relations, as did charges of unfair trading practices.[8] With the collapse of the Japanese property and stock bubbles at the end of 1989, the country's economic growth leveled off and largely stagnated for a generation, thus removing American worry about being overtaken by the vaunted Japanese business model and Japan's consensus-oriented, high-achieving society. Japan's sudden slowdown not only caught America by surprise but served both to remove a potential competitor for global power and to open up a spot, so to speak, for another rising power to grab Washington's attention.

A final factor that inflated American expectations for China was the beginning of China's own economic spurt, widely dated from then-paramount leader Deng Xiaoping's legendary "southern tour" in 1992, which restarted the economic reforms he initially promulgated in 1979. Deng's famous exhortations to create capitalism with Chinese characteristics, perhaps best summed up in the apocryphal slogan "To get rich is glorious," seemed to offer validation that Western-style capitalism was the wave of the present. Deng's policies also served as assurance that China would not fall back into the isolation and madness of Mao's era, where the Great Leap Forward and the Cultural Revolution had largely destroyed a generation of Chinese growth and scarred its